

at Dingle Bay. The last 600 miles (960km) of the flight were relatively straightforward. Lindbergh entered France at Cherbourg and followed a lighted route toward Paris, which appeared to him as “a patch of starlit earth under a starlit sky.”

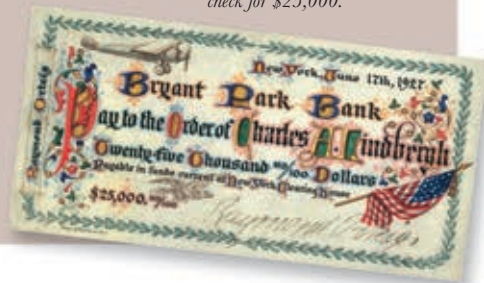
News of the American's imminent arrival set Paris alight. A vast traffic jam developed as hundreds of thousands of Parisians headed for Le Bourget airfield. An American expatriate, Harry Crosby, described the chaotic scene: “Then sharp swift in the gold glare of the searchlights a small white hawk of a plane swoops hawklike down and across the field – C'est lui, Lindbergh, LINDBERGH! and there is pandemonium [like] wild animals let loose and a stampede toward the plane...”

After a flight of 33 hours 30 minutes Lindbergh emerged from total solitude into the clutches of an hysterical mob. He had become the most famous man in the world.



HOMEcoming HERO

After his record-breaking flight, Lindbergh returned from Paris to a hero's welcome. A ticker-tape parade through New York was witnessed by four million people. For his amazing endeavor, Lindbergh was promoted from captain to colonel in the US Army Air Corps Reserve. He also received the first Distinguished Flying Cross to be awarded and a check for \$25,000.



conscious aviation administrator William P. MacCracken, who commented acidly: “He's not going to help commercial aviation if he keeps dropping these airplanes around the countryside.” MacCracken must have been relieved when Lindbergh quit airmail flying to take up a more prominent challenge.

Nonstop challenge

French-born American hotelier Raymond Orteig had put up a \$25,000 prize for a nonstop flight between New York and Paris in 1919, but it was only in the mid-1920s that interest in this challenge began to raise a buzz among fliers and the press. In 1926 French wartime ace René Fonck announced that he intended to mount the first attempt on the prize. Fonck and his team had Igor Sikorsky create a trimotor version of his two-engined S-35 transport plane. It was to take a crew of four across the Atlantic in some style – fixtures included the latest radio equipment, seats with red leather upholstery, and a bed. But a rush to carry out the flight before the winter weather set in meant there was not enough time to test the airplane fully loaded. On September 21, in front of a large crowd, Fonck attempted to take off from Roosevelt Field bound for Paris. The aircraft never left the ground. Spectators saw it plunge down an embankment at the end of the runway and explode in a fireball. Fonck and one crew member escaped, but two of the crew were killed.

Obviously, such drama only brought popular interest to a higher pitch. By the spring of 1927 more famous pilots were lining up for a crack at the prize. Commander Richard Byrd was planning to fly to Paris in a Fokker trimotor, while in France war aces Charles Nungesser and François Coli announced that they were preparing to fly to New York. But the prize seemed jinxed. Byrd's Fokker crashed on its first trial flight in April, virtually putting him out of the running. Ten days later, pilots Noel Davis and Stanton Wooster, who were being sponsored by the American Legion, crashed and died on their last test flight before attempting to fly to Paris.

On May 8, Nungesser and the one-eyed Coli left Le Bourget aerodrome, Paris, in their single-engined Levasseur biplane *L'Oiseau Blanc* (“The White Bird”), confidently expecting to arrive in New York the following day. After leaving the coast of France, they were never seen again. The agonizing wait for news of the two French aces, and the slow ebbing of hope, stirred deep emotions in France and unquestionably contributed to the intensity of the reception



ILL-FATED WHITE BIRD

L'Oiseau Blanc was the Levasseur biplane in which Charles Nungesser and François Coli set out to fly from Paris to New York two weeks before Lindbergh. They disappeared without trace.

CHARLES A. LINDBERGH

SON OF A MINNESOTA CONGRESSMAN, Charles A. Lindbergh (1902–74) was a shy and solitary child, qualities that developed into mild-mannered self-reliance in his adulthood. Completely out of step with the clichéd image of youth in America's “Roaring Twenties,” he did not smoke, dance, or drink alcohol. Obsessed with flying, he drifted from barnstorming to a spell in the Army Air Corps and, in 1926, a job as an airmail pilot.

At first he handled the extraordinary fame brought by his transatlantic flight remarkably well, impressing everyone with his charm and poise. He married the talented Anne Morrow and became the world's leading ambassador for aviation. But after the kidnap and murder of their infant son in 1932, Lindbergh was increasingly driven to escape the storm of publicity that surrounded his every action. In the late 1930s he developed an admiration for aspects of Nazi Germany and campaigned to keep the United States out of the war in Europe. Although he took an active part in the war against Japan after 1941, his reputation never fully recovered.



LONE EAGLE

Charles Lindbergh's courage, daring, and endurance helped him to become the most famous aviator of his day and did much to inspire people's faith in flying. He is shown here posing by the Spirit of St. Louis.